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Section Title(S): (1) Introduction. • (2) Ownership.

This type of environmental determinism is in no sense absolute, as immediately becomes apparent when one considers that Ghanzi European beef rancher, Kgalagadi pastoralist and Bushman hunter-foodgatherer all live in very much the same, and in some cases identical, basic environment but have widely differing types of social organization and material cultures. It is a man's nature to alter nature, and the rancher, with his technology which was initially developed in Europe, can erect a sufficient barrier between himself and nature and so alter his environment (e.g. by using a machine imported from South Africa driven by an internal combustion engine made in England, running on fuel pumped out of the ground in Texas or the Middle East to sink a borehole and reach underground water which is then pumped up) to provide himself, his garden and his stock with an adequate and permanent supply of water on a farm where no water stood before. Nearly a century ago the Kgalagadi learnt his well-digging from the Tswana who, in turn, had developed their skill in other, kinder parts of the country, and he now runs breeds of cattle which were introduced by Africans from further north and by Europeans, and plants crops which were domesticated on the other side of the sub-continent. These then by altering the circumstances of their environments by means of imported devices and skills, erect barriers which protect them from the blows of nature and so free themselves from some of the limitations of their environments. But the G/wi of the central desert, having lived in isolation, has not the advantage of these importations, is not able to do much to alter his surroundings and is therefore subject to its limitations to a much greater extent.

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(2) *Ownership.*

Individual ownership is limited to an individual's clothing, a man's weapons and implements and a woman's household goods. Food once collected, is also an object of ownership. The list of material goods owned by anyone, or even those owned by a family, is very short. In the first place the means of production of goods is extremely primitive. Secondly, there is minimal processing of raw materials before consumption, which excludes a wide range of processing devices necessary in other, more complex cultures. Thirdly, the G/wi move their villages frequently and, as all goods have to be carried by the family owning them, nothing but essential baggage is allowed to accumulate. The concept of ownership is watered down to some extent by the mechanics of the kinship system which allows very free use of property by the joking partners of an individual. What I mean by this is that there is little point in concerning oneself excessively with one's rights to property when it is going to be borrowed at any moment, and when you can substitute your own item of borrowed property by simply borrowing somebody else's.

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There is almost nothing which is capable of being inherited, as all an individual's possessions, with the exception of beadwork, are broken on his or her grave after death. Status grades do not exist and the only status which is valued and which can be inherited is band membership. As this can be acquired by other means, the value of its inheritance is lessened.

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